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Orrin Keepnews

Orrin Keepnews was born in New York City on March 2, 1923. He has played an important role in jazz as a record producer, writer and as a creative force with Riverside, Milestone and Landmark Records. Orrin produced classic recordings with Thelonious Monk, Bill Evans and Cannonball Adderley and continues to work in jazz from his home in San Francisco.

Orrin was interviewed in San Francisco, California on August 7, 2002 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in San Francisco filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm extremely pleased to be speaking with Orrin Keepnews today and trying to figure out how to introduce you, you're a lot of things, writer, producer and —

OK: I tend to think of myself primarily at least as a producer, and that's the way I would prefer to be remembered. If I were to have a gravestone that's what it should — if it gives occupation on gravestones, that's what I want.

MR: Right. Well I have to congratulate you on the contribution you've made to the art form called jazz. It's really quite amazing the things you've been involved in and the careers that you have helped.

OK: Well I must admit that I look back on it with a good deal of satisfaction. I've been very fortunate because in this business in particular, a lot of the associations that you form, at least initially, are accidental as hell. If someone tells me that I have been helpful to this or that career that's exactly the thing that I want to hear because I have always looked on the role of the producer in a very specific way. Now one of the hardest things, and I've been at it, I'm getting perilously close to my fiftieth anniversary in this business, but I still have to pause usually when I'm asked to make some kind of definition of what it is I do, because for better or worse, I don't know about other things because I've only done this really, but jazz record producers do a little bit of everything, as there is always a shortage of personnel, and it's to me, the most important role is what I have taken to repetitiously referring to as being a catalytic agent. That I am supposed to create the circumstances under which the artist can work most effectively. That is, I've finally got it boiled down to that one mantra and that's what I am, that's what I do. I think one of the great things about — that statement is generally true, but the details of its implementation are constantly changing. There are no — almost literally — there are no two artists who can be dealt with in the same way. There are perhaps no two record dates that can be dealt with in the same way. That may be pushing it a little bit, but fundamentally that to me is what the continuing challenge is all about, that's why I didn't get bored a long time ago

with doing this. The only real serious variation is that I have — I used to say in recent years — but for a lot of years, a lot of my attention has been focused on reissues and obviously the procedures are a little different there. For the most part that makes it possible to get into cliches like well I spent the whole day in the studio with Louis Armstrong or Duke Ellington or Fats Waller, and he didn't give me a hard time. But that joke got busted about a year ago because one of my most recent reissue projects was with Artie Shaw, who is now 92, is quite firmly there, could not possibly have ever been more opinionated in his life than he is now, and so I could not say I spent the day with Artie Shaw and he did not give me a hard time. He did give me a hard time. But it was a wonderful experience working with him actually, and it literally I think it's about the only circumstances under which you can be working on pre-tape material with the artist. And there ain't too many people who still have firm opinions, he still doesn't like "Begin the Beguine," which after all I guess was a 1937 or 8 recording. Maybe it was '36. I don't have to remember those things, they're all firmly written down. Those discographies are unchanging. But what I consider the most important work has been the things that I've been able to do with a very large handful of artists who are important, whose work is and should be lasting and you know I know for a minute that it's not my creativity. My job was to do two things. One is to appreciate and the other is to facilitate. And I usually don't use such glorious words to describe it but I've always been the guy that was able to get it done, which kind of surprises me sometimes. I don't think of myself as being firm, as being decision-maker, I certainly do not believe in the auteur theory of jazz direction, I don't think, and there have been people and we won't bother to name names but there have been other jazz record producers who clearly do think of themselves as king makers. And I never did. It just got to be the point of hey, somebody's got to make the decision and okay, that's one of the things that I'm here for. Sometimes you might make decisions because nobody else is even in the position to even be aware of the need for a decision. Initially I learned I guess — well let me say this — everything I learned initially I learned from the best possible teacher as far as I'm concerned. I owe my entire career, whatever success I may have, the man that is firmly responsible for that is Thelonious Monk. There is no question in my mind that I gained tremendously from the initially very frightening fact that this was the first artist of any significance who I worked with. I mean I had done a few things — before I got involved with Thelonious I had been in the studio with people like Randy Weston, Mundell Lowe, Billy Taylor, you know all pussycats. But here was a real tough cookie. Here was a man who knew what he wanted, thought he knew exactly how to get it, frequently was right, and the example I used to use, in other words the old fashion way of teaching a child to swim is you toss him into the deep end of the pool and if he doesn't go under he's learned to swim. Well I learned — that's

exactly how I learned to swim. And it was, I also will say that, I said it many years ago with what I have learned I would never entrust as valuable and volatile a commodity as Thelonious to anybody as totally ignorant and inexperienced as I was at the time. But fortunately one of the great advantages of that, well basically it's a 1950s phenomenon primarily, it happened a little before that, it happened a little after that, but the idea of the jazz fan as self-made jazz record producer actually the art owes a great deal to that phenomenon and a number of very important — Alfred Lion comes to mind, Milt Gabler, Lester Koenig at Contemporary Records. I don't want to start naming names because you always leave out what you shouldn't. But practically everybody, and it was very frequently exactly the same circumstances. If it was your company and you said you were the producer, there wasn't anybody that was going to tell you you weren't. So you did it. And most of us I must admit were self-appointed. Because I had a partner and Bill Grauer was initially a man, he was a serious jazz record collector and knew a hell of a lot more than I did about things but he naturally gravitated toward the business end of the company and so suddenly I found myself the creative director of Riverside Records and I made the most of it. The Monk experience taught me, quite seriously, not only how to behave in the presence of genius of a major artist, how to work effectively or hopefully effectively with somebody like that, and how to accomplish what you feel you have to accomplish in the face of who and what that artist is. And having survived Monk I have been fond of saying I could never again be frightened of any jazz musician. So it was, quite seriously, Sonny Rollins once in an interview with somebody, I think Stanley Crouch interviewed him at one point and Sonny, who of course during one of his sabbatical periods had spent some time in India, said that he thought that Monk was not a teacher so much as he was a guru, in the sense that a guru is somebody who enables you to bring out the best qualities in yourself. And Mr. Rollins, who is in addition to being an extremely articulate player, is also an extremely articulate thinker and expresser in words, this was a very specific point that Sonny was making and I think it's incredibly accurate. Of course Monk has never had a student per se and never had. One of the true marks of an important person is that you will continue indefinitely to refer to them in the present tense. And I think that's not just a slip. It may initially be that, but there are a lot of people — one of the glories of — thank God they invented the phonograph record. It keeps people very much alive. And unfortunately they haven't worked out a way where they can vary what's on the records, but in a sense we have with all of the emphasis on alternate takes that's come about and the reissue scene. But these people are, the ones who remain a living presence, I still have that same attitude that combination of respect and veneration and pride, I do feel proud of what I have been able to help them to accomplish. I know damn well that there are circumstances, I don't have to be immodest

about it, in which if not for me and the record company that I was operating and the way in which we proceeded with things — certainly a lot of careers would not have happened in the same way. I'm not saying that it wouldn't have happened, but knowing what I do about — I'll tell you, knowing what I do about some of the personalities that I dealt with I still haven't figured out whether it was just luck of the draw or whether this is a more prevalent attitude than anybody appreciates but I sure have had a run of artists who never really believed that they have played it right. Who have to do another take because they didn't get it yet, they haven't done the best that they can do. And it's amazing, I mean it's a perfectly good description of Rollins, of Wes Montgomery, of Bill Evans. That's a pretty good round up there. We used to have a standing joke about the creation, for recording purposes of a demon band, which would be made up of all of these people who never believed that they had done anything properly. There were a number of other people who I didn't necessarily work much with directly but who were in the same category, J.J. Johnson, Percy Heath, a lot of people. And we were going to form this dream band as it were, there were two problems. One is obviously with that band you would never get an acceptable take on even one tune, and secondly you wouldn't be able to find a drummer for that band. Drummers do not suffer from this problem. But other than that, that's one of the major characteristics of jazz in my time anyhow. Well among other things, I mean somebody's got to say hey, enough of this, let's quit crapping around and go on to the next tune. Or, take my word for it, I really think we've got it there. One or the other of those takes has got it and we can always edit, but believe me let's go on. And frequently the musician has no choice but to believe you, and so—

MR: Let me ask you, what was in your childhood that steered you into jazz listening as a hobby first?

OK: I don't have the faintest idea.

MR: Really.

OK: I come from a totally non-musical family background. I remember quite distinctly that when I was about six a relative was breaking up a household and had a piano that she was willing to give to us and my mother said if we have a piano in the house, will you take lessons, which was a pretty stupid question for my mother to ask me, and I said hell no, or whatever a 6-year-old said, the equivalent of that, to my mother. And so I grew up quite non-musical. But what you have to remember is that when I was growing up there we were in the 30s. One of the advantages of being my age, there was an awful lot of remarkably good music on the radio. There were some pretty wonderful — the big band situation. In my recent experience with Artie Shaw I was able to point out to him, I was barely a teenager when he was first becoming a star. I said in my day if you were at all interested in music you could not equivocate. For example, you had to either be for

Benny Goodman or for Artie Shaw. You couldn't waffle on that. And Artie, among other things has a wonderful sense of humor but not about himself. His response to that was to tell me quite seriously, "well Benny was a better clarinet player, but I was a better musician." But at any rate you listened to a lot of that. You listened to a lot of Ellington. I mean I think the Ellington band was one of the first musics that I was conscious of. And then of course the other strange thing was I was going to clubs and hearing live music in New York on 52nd Street or at Nick's in Greenwich Village at an obscenely early age because one of the things you've got to realize is that before World War II, before universal military service, nobody carried — and particularly in an area like New York where nobody had a driver's license under any circumstances, nobody in Manhattan ever drove a car particularly in the 30s — there was nothing to card you with. We didn't carry — nobody had the concept of carrying identification with you. So if you were — if you looked able to walk into the club and if you had the seventy-five cents that a drink would cost, nobody would give you a hard time. Or you learned. I mean some of those clip joints on 52nd Street no self-respecting child would want to be caught in. But Hickory House was a lovely, friendly place where the band played inside this big oval bar and if you got sort of off in the corner on a weekday night and you ordered a Tom Collins—

MR: A tall one.

OK: You learned the tallest drink to get. The bartender would leave you alone. So now that meant, Hickory House for example okay, Hickory House mid to late-30s, I'm listening to Joe Marsala, who not infrequently would have Bud Freeman, Dave Tough, and hey it was a long time before I realized that not every jazz band had a harpist in it. It was Joe's wife.

MR: Oh right.

OK: Adele Girard played harp and was usually part of his band. But and then I discovered Nick's and the whole point was also, see you could get in, a high school kid could get in there pretty easily, it was very inexpensive. It got to be, perhaps the music was secondary and in fact what a great place for a cheap date. So I do remember that that was part of the picture.

MR: What's a clip joint?

OK: What's a clip joint?

MR: Yeah.

OK: That's — are you asking me seriously?

MR: Yeah I am. I don't know the term.

OK: Well it's a joint at which you get clipped. It's a — you are aware of the reputation of the 52nd Street ex-speakeasy night clubs, and swing street and such, where oh just possibly the drinks were a little watered, just possibly you were being overcharged. That's — I'm sorry I'm using old fashioned—

MR: No, I wanted to make sure what you were taking about.

OK: Fine. Okay. The world has gone on to other forms of waylaying people. I mean I'm not old enough to have been around when the press gangs were kidnapping sailors and putting them on ships in the harbor, but this is almost it. But no the point is so what I'm saying is it's a combination of a certain amount of osmosis. Pop music was in the air to a very large extent and it was very close to being or actually was jazz at this point, and then also physical circumstances made it possible for me to have direct listening experience even though it wasn't an overwhelming love of music maybe that led me in there in the first place. But I heard it, I listened to it, so that by the time I got into the Army, which was when I was about like just short of being 21 when I got into the armed forces, I was sufficiently immersed in music at a time that, just a couple of years ago when a guy that I had been hanging out with a good deal in those days, in my Army days we lost sight of each other for decades and then re-encountered each other and we were reminiscing, actually strictly by mail, he lives in Europe now, but reminiscing about the old days and the thing that had been the first bond between us was the mutual love of the Ellington band. So that I was sufficiently into it. Then when I came out of the Army and went — my family was living in the immediate vicinity of Columbia University. I had graduated from Columbia. And I went back in the general campus area, after being in the armed forces I felt I had three years of total illiteracy. I had been an English major. I intended to go into some form of writing or publishing or whatnot, and I felt that I needed a kind of a crash course in being literate again. So I went back on campus, got into the graduate English school and wasn't looking for a degree, didn't stay there that long, but by doing that there was a group of people who I had known, not necessarily all that well but who I had known in the pre-war period which included Bill Grauer, who in the late 40s took over as publisher of a very esoteric jazz magazine called *The Record Changer* which basically it survived on the basis of having in its columns mail order buying, selling and auctioning of rare 78 old jazz records. And at that point I had gotten what I considered the proper kind of job for me, I was a young editor in a book publishing house. I like to say I worked at Simon & Schuster so long ago that I worked for Mr. Simon and Mr. Schuster and I really did. But I had this relationship going with — a working scene going with Grauer, for example, and I became editor of that publication. And among the things that happened early on was that Bill and I were invited down to the Greenwich Village home of Alfred and Lorraine Lion, because Alfred had just started to push Blue Note into modern jazz and we were claiming that *The Record Changer* would be open to considering all kinds of jazz, not just the traditional which it had previously been involved with. And so we were invited down there to meet and to listen to test pressings from the first recording session for Blue Note of Thelonious Monk. I was so damn dumb

in those days that I did not realize the impossibility of what I wisely set out to do, but on the spot it was a big, sprawling Greenwich Village studio living room, Monk and I went off into a corner disregarding all the other people there and I interviewed him for an article that appeared in the magazine. A number of years later when I had a fledgling record company and had heard the accurate rumor that Monk, who at that time was with Prestige, was very unhappy with where he was, they were not happy with him, he wasn't selling records, at least he was a famous eccentric by that point, and they would be perfectly happy to get rid of him. But of course they wouldn't have if they had known that another record company was interested. So we had a fairly clandestine meeting with Monk, sort of came to a gentleman's agreement kind of situation, and what Prestige wanted was to be repaid not what — its royalty account was in the red, that's always quite fictional — but the actual dollar amount that he had been over advanced by them which was $128 and change, so I gave him $130 and he went, actually the offices of Prestige were around the corner from the offices of Riverside in those days, he went around the corner and I still have in my possession — I insisted that he had to give me the original release letter, which had been prepared, saying your check for and then that was scratched out and cash was put in, a letter from Bob Weinstock to Thelonious Monk releasing him of his contractual obligations to Prestige. Monk then proceeded to sign with Riverside and in a very real sense that was the beginning of Riverside as a company to be taken seriously and it was, as far as I'm concerned, it was the beginning of my career as a jazz record producer. Now I had said previously to you that a lot of my life was accidental, that's pretty damned accidental.

MR: Well it's almost like the fact that you were so new to it was to your advantage.

OK: Well the interesting thing is that when we learned of the availability of, or potential availability of Monk, I had no idea that he would have any recollection of this whole initial encounter in light of that, but upon re-meeting him he proceeded to let us know he knew exactly who we were and he informed me that the article that I had written about him, not only obviously did he like it but he said it had been the first piece about him to ever appear in a national magazine. Well *The Record Changer* was a national magazine by courtesy. I suppose you could call it that, but the whole point was that it was the fact of my having done that bit of strange journalism that was the key thing. It meant that Monk remembered who I was, remembered me and the publication favorably and, you know, what the hell, was willing to take a chance with our scene.

MR: And you made a transition yourself, like a lot of your colleagues, from being quote the moldy fig traditionalist listener, into a more modern style. Did it happen quickly for you?

OK: Actually we can stay right with the same guy. As far as I'm concerned it primarily happened by way of Monk. Initially when I came back from the Pacific in 19— the

beginning of 1945 I guess or beginning of '46, I'm sorry, the beginning of '46, the people knowing that hey this is a guy that's interested in jazz, you've got to hear what's going on now. So I was forced to listen to a couple of the Dizzy Gillespie/Charlie Parker Guild records. And I thought this was some of the most outrageous noise I had ever heard. I had no ability to relate to it. And that didn't mean anything to me and I continued in my set ways of believing that the world was bounded by nothing more extreme than Jelly Roll Morton, Louis Armstrong and Duke Ellington. That was about all I was willing to admit to. And by early in 1948 is when — the time of my meeting with Monk — it was the first time I'd heard Monk play. I listened to the test pressings of his first couple of Blue Note numbers and as it turns out I think one of the really important things that was involved there was that the drummer on that date was Art Blakey. So by God regardless of style, when Art Blakey played you were conscious of the beat and you were conscious of the rhythmic underpinning of that and somehow I was able to relate to what Monk was playing. Again I can't particularly explain it to you, but this was the first modern jazz that I found attractive and interesting and I found myself able to digest. And it moved forward from that point. Now one of the strange things is I didn't have too much of an awareness of Monk's background and such. But a couple of years later the fourth album I did with Monk was a solo piano album. And in the course of one of those sessions he did an improvised blues. And standing in the control room to get a listening to a playback of that, Monk turned to me and said, "aah I sound just like James P. Johnson." It was the first that I knew that Monk knew who the hell James P. Johnson was. But as it turned out Monk had grown up in the West Sixties in New York in the same area that Johnson lived in when Monk was a teenager. He could sneak in to this or that local bar and hear James P. He became quite fascinated and quite influenced by it, and there's an awful lot of stride piano in Thelonious. But I was already pretty deeply involved with Monk before it was made clear to me how deliberate all this was. That he was in a sense a disciple or considered himself a disciple of James P. Johnson.

MR: Well in your book you had said, "understanding the blues long has been the rule of thumb for evaluating jazz musicians."

OK: I still stick to that. There's no reason to change that statement.

MR: Right. So Thelonious certainly had a finger on the blues, at least what to do with it within his style.

OK: Oh yeah. No question about that.

MR: Let me go backwards just a little bit. You were in the South Pacific.

OK: I was on Guam. I was a navigator radar operator on B-29s. I did a lot of dropping of bombs on Japan, which I'm resolutely not proud of for the rest of my life, so—

MR: At that time you were 23?

OK: 22 maybe, around in there.

MR: How did you feel about it at the time?

OK: At the time you didn't feel about it. There is a — I mean I'm no great expert on it but there were two years in my life where I was involved in armed conflict and I think that one of the ways in which some of us emotionally survive was a form of anesthetizing yourself. You did not think about what you were doing. You did not — I mean I don't think, unfortunately at the end of the war, after the war was over, I flew a couple of missions where we were taking a batch of generals up to evaluate what had been done to Tokyo. So we flew in the daytime at pretty low levels over Tokyo, which is something I had never done before, and I was able to see — see Tokyo, I'll take a lot of credit for the fact that Tokyo was a modern city that is almost entirely a post-war city, it looked to me to be about fifty percent burned out, I mean put it that way. And that was the first time, the shock of that hit me. Not to turn this into too much of a war memoir but basically B-29 flights were — we didn't do very much daytime formation bombing which involved demolition bombs. We normally did night flights where you just flew in a single file so basically you were following at a decent interval the plane ahead of you and we were dropping incendiary bombs so that what you did was it was a very lazy form of bombing, you just dropped on the fires that were in front of you. And if the first guy in line had been way off target, we all were because nobody did anything else but that. But the whole point there was that you could be very detached. You didn't have to force yourself to think that you really were causing fires to happen in a large metropolitan city that was there. And you could block that out pretty good because hey, you had no alternative. This is what you were doing and this is what you were doing in the great war and I'm not saying — I've long since given up figuring out whether this was in many respects a good or a bad thing. However, at this time of year as we get around the middle of August every year I am forced to think that in my personal opinion the damn atom bomb never should have been dropped, and let's not get into the aesthetics or morality of that, but you have led me to this point in time so I make that statement. But you blot it out, the implications of what you were doing, I think because it was pretty necessary.

MR: Right. Were the Japanese putting up a defense against your planes at that time?

OK: In the latter stages no. There was always a fair amount of antiaircraft fire but not — there were virtually no fighter planes. I mean the Japanese Air Force was pretty much shot to hell in the last months of the war which is when I was primarily — the time I was primarily there. But let's get back to jazz.

MR: All right. The early things with Monk certainly must have opened your ears up and it seems like some of the stuff that he taught you might not have been apparent right at that

time? Was there kind of like a delay in certain incidents where you understood afterwards what he was trying to show you?

OK: Well no, when I talk about learning from Monk, to me the most important learning from Monk that I did was a matter of learning attitudes. Learning how to conduct myself in the studio in relation to the important, demanding, impatient artist, which is what all good artists should be. And it wasn't so much — I did discover for example that — eventually I discovered that the main cause of Monk's impatience, and his impatience with his fellow musicians, was that as far as he was concerned there wasn't anything that difficult about his music. He grasped it. How come you couldn't? One of my favorite lines which happens to have survived on a scrap of tape from a session that Coleman Hawkins and John Coltrane were involved in is Hawkins had been having trouble with the turnaround on one particular number and Monk can be heard saying to him, "whatsa matter? You're supposed to be the great Coleman Hawkins. How come you can't play that?" He didn't say you're the great Coleman Hawkins how come you can't — you're supposed to be the great Coleman Hawkins. I've always treasured that remark. But fundamentally it's that I, again, understanding what I consider to be the root causes of his impatience which were that he didn't know what the hell was it that was giving you this trouble. I'm not having any trouble with this. And that he was an excellent teacher as far as logistics is concerned. I learned how to conduct myself in the studio, I learned when to push, when not to push, and how much of that has got to be instinctive and is a matter of reading what the artist has in mind, and I also learned to be very wary of arbitrary musical judgements. I think this is perhaps one of the things that has led to my lifelong distaste for and distrust of jazz criticism. Because it has always been full of people who feel that it's necessary for them to strike a pose, to take a position, to give us THE judgment from heaven as to whether this is good or that is bad or whatnot. And you know that's not necessary. And it's never been necessary. Music is something that gets evaluated very personally. I mean yeah, proficient playing and non-proficient playing is generally, you can make distinctions there, except a hell of a lot of people spent a lot of time in the early days saying that Monk couldn't play the piano and they were wrong. But in general I just feel that — now value judgements are very important. I have lots of value judgements and have always made such judgements, and I have only under very rare and unusual circumstances allowed myself to get involved professionally with a musician that I didn't have strong positive feelings for, but that didn't necessarily have to involve compatibility between two — I can approve of two musicians who wouldn't necessarily approve of each other, approaching them from — and I've never felt it necessary for there to be an arbitrary set of standards and I'm very wary of judging performances. I will judge an artist. I fundamentally, if I, in my years as somebody who was involved with scouting

and signing artists, I approved of somebody, I liked what he was doing, I felt it made sense to me, should make sense to the world, I was willing to get involvement there, then I'm making a commitment at that point. That commitment involves working with that artist, getting from him as well as giving to him, but it does not necessarily involve my deciding that what he is doing at a given moment is good or bad, whether it meets with my approval is pretty God damned irrelevant. I am not more gifted than the artist in determining — this is a hard thing to articulate — I'm not talking about suspension of judgement. What I'm saying is I tend to make my judgements initially. I may revise them later but let's let that go for the moment. If I have felt strongly enough positively about an artist to want to become involved in working with him that involves approving his taste. It has to involve approving his judgement. Therefore it involves that I am not going to nickel and dime the situation and decide that on this particular point I really know better than he does. And that's where I part company with the people who feel that the only way they're going to make their living is by making immediate sweeping judgements.

MR: Isn't part of your role in that situation to know not necessarily what is best, it's what that performer is best — what his best is?

OK: Yeah. Well again, when I speak of myself as a catalytic agent it's endeavoring to provide the circumstances under which the artist can deliver to the best of his ability, not distracted or sidetracked or disturbed. And that implies of course — not necessarily my approval of what he is doing, it implies my approval of the rightness of his doing what he chooses to do.

MR: Well Thelonious was apparently, in a lot of cases, hard to play with? Hard to get used to? Is that a fair statement?

OK: No. Because first of all there was — working with Thelonious was not something that you did, I mean you being another musician, very arbitrarily or casually. If you were playing in a band with Monk or on a record date with Monk it was based on his awareness of you and his approval and his considering that it was likely that you would be able to perform his music. Because again, playing with Monk involved one of two things. Either playing Monk compositions or playing standards that he found he could adapt. So that the hard part sort of came first. It came before you got to the starting gate. I don't think it's fair to say that people found it hard playing with him. First of all people that were invited to play with him generally turned out to have the ability to do so. It was his judgement in the first place, and his judgment was pretty God damn — well look at the personnel situation. Look at how long a time, on the whole, individual sidemen worked with him. Yes some didn't, changes were made here and there and various circumstances entered into it, but by and large it's not like gee it's hard to play with Monk and there's some kind of revolving door there, that is absolutely not the case.

MR: I had come across this comment from Miles Davis—

OK: Well comments from Miles Davis should be taken with grains of salt. But what did Miles say?

MR: He was listening to Sonny Rollins with Thelonious Monk, "The Way You Look Tonight," and he says, "I don't see how a record company can record something like that. You know the way Monk plays he never gives any support to a rhythm section. When I had him on my date I had him lay out." You know, has there been circumstances—

OK: Oh come on he had him lay out on one tune, the whole celebrated story, as Monk has said, there never was any danger of there being a fight because I would have killed him. And he's right. Despite all the photos of Miles in boxing gear. Miles, this is a whole other subject but you brought Miles into it. Miles Davis, who I never worked with but who I knew pretty well over a very long period of time, and basically I'm going to say just in the whole pantheon of things, not that he ever asked me to but I approve of Miles Davis as a player. I think that Miles was an incredibly important player. I think that the Miles Davis, THE Miles Davis Sextet, which among other things had a couple of artists in it who I have worked with very closely over the years, was perhaps the seminal group in quote modern jazz. I mean that sextet and with either of the drummers in it, whether it was Philly Joe, who was only briefly in the sextet, or Jimmy Cobb, who is now its only surviving member, but that was a wonderful group. Miles was, in terms of ideas, in terms of execution, I'm among those who like Miles as a trumpet player. You can get into arguments about that. But Miles as a maker of deliberately controversial statements is another whole thing. If you take seriously, on the surface, what Miles says under certain circumstances, as somebody did because what you just quoted got picked up and published and immortalized, if you took it seriously you were playing Miles' game. That's all. Miles was an agent provocateur of the first order. And so that, and you have to also understand that he was not the only one like that. There's a lot, there's a lot of this people-baiting that goes on in Monk too. And Monk would — well Monk was supposed to be very difficult to understand, just conversationally I mean, not musically. And that was one of the things that was always very strange to me because the first time I met him we sat down and I did an interview with him and I had no problem whatsoever. I subsequently discovered it was very simple. He was as easy or difficult to understand as he wanted to be. I think you could probably — I claimed you could chart it and come out with about seven different levels of intelligibility, as he wanted to play the game under particular circumstances. So above all Miles and Monk coming into association with each other are coming in conflict as in the date that Miles is talking about, that famous Christmas eve 1954 session with Milt Jackson and etcetera. That must have been a hell of a date to be a fly on the wall at because these two personalities, each of whom always

demanded to be the centerpiece, to be the focal point of what was going on, to be in control, coming head to head, actually it is a wonder that they didn't really start duking it out together. But Monk said they didn't because he would have killed him. But anyway you must — particularly when you're dealing with famous remarks and famous incidents, try to look behind the surface as much as you can.

MR: Okay. With a whole bag of salt.

OK: Yes.

MR: You were, according to Gene Lees, I believe said you were the biggest Bill Evans nut he ever knew.

OK: Probably. Probably. I heard Bill Evans, this I guess is a story that's been told often but it's worth telling again. I first heard Bill Evans under the most wrong circumstances imaginable. One of the first artists that Riverside got involved with was Mundell Lowe, and Mundell — who is still alive and well and an excellent guitarist — but was very much a part of a very white jazz scene of that time. But he had known Bill back at — what is it, northeast or southeast or whatever Louisiana College, the small educational organization that Bill went to college at, Mundell was there. And so that Mundell was one of the few people that Bill knew in New York when Bill was first on the scene. And Mundell was tremendously impressed with him. And they were very close. I think Mundell explained it they had the same psychiatrist. But one day the phone rang at the Riverside offices and Mundell wanted me and Bill Grauer both to get on the phone at the same time, and he proceeded to play a tape of a piano player he wanted us to be interested in. Well first of all as a professional musician he damn well should have known better than to in effect play a demo tape over the telephone. I mean come on. The quality control at AT&T was even worse than it is now. So it wasn't a matter of oh boy, that's the greatest piano player I ever heard, I've got to get him, it was, despite all the crap, I'm hearing enough there that I want to hear more. This guy is pretty impressive. And so I went to a couple of these funky clubs in Greenwich Village where Bill was playing in quartets with somebody like Tony Scott or Don Elliot and got to know Bill, and eventually was able to persuade Bill that he should go in to the studio and make a record, which he was not terribly inclined to do. He put together a trio because Paul Motian, and I'll digress in a minute about the name of that drummer, Paul, and then the bass player was Teddy Kottick. And we went in and did a basically trio record with a few unaccompanied solo things including the first recording of "Waltz for Debby." And I happened to — and here's the interesting point. Bill Evans, as a player, even though stylistically in the beginning there was a lot more bop in him than there was, then it very quickly got to be. Somehow or other you listen to that first record and you're faced with the fact that Bill Evans, who was showing his influences very much at that time, was

capable of being influenced simultaneously by Horace Silver and Lennie Tristano. You try that sometime and you know what you get? You get Bill Evans. And the other fact is that yes, I was tremendously impressed by Bill and the interesting thing about Bill of course was that in an age when then, as is true now I'm quite sure, of course it is, guys will kill to get into the recording studio. Everybody is always ready and more than ready to record. After Bill did that first record which got very, very good critical reaction, which sold practically nothing, it was very hard to get him back in the studio. Now again, one of the things we should not neglect is the strange attitudes of most of us foolish people who were fans transmuted into record companies. We were doing this thing and I don't think we ever even thought seriously about whether it was a commercially viable thing to be doing. We were in business to make records. And we were very happy to be making records. It was kind of rough perhaps if, as I did, you had a family. Somehow or other I managed to eke out a living. The record company sure didn't contribute very much to it in the early days. But the fact that Bill Evans made a record that didn't sell a God damn, that was — let's put it this way it did not reach in its initial year it did not reach four figures. It didn't crack a thousand in its first year. Didn't do that until a year later when he was discovered by Miles. And when he was playing — well initial sales the first year on the first Bill Evans record, 800 copies. But in a revolutionary move, in the second year when he was now known as a sideman with Miles Davis it sold another 800. Now that cumulative total still isn't much but any record selling as much in the second year as it has in the first, that's a phenomenon. Bill — I played hell trying to get him back into the studio. Actually what happened was it then, it got to be right after he left Miles, and just prior to the time of his starting what would be his own trio for the rest of his life, he made that second record in which Philly Joe, who he had known from the Miles period, and Sam Jones, who he was very impressed with. It's kind of interesting, Bill Evans, who a lot of people — whose music a lot of people wrongly confuse with Debussy — being attracted by what was probably the best walking roots bass player that we had in jazz at that time, and that's a wonderful trio record, which I for some reason was brash enough to come up with the title "Everybody Digs Bill Evans." And that was the record, the cover of which consists of laudatory quotes from four different people. Well what happened with that was I had read — the Miles quote there is something that had appeared in a *Down Beat* article, Miles talking about Bill. And that's when the idea got into my head and I said well it shouldn't be too difficult. I know that a lot of other piano players feel strongly about him and I know that Cannonball feels strongly about him. Cannonball by that time was working with me. I got a quote from Cannonball just by asking for it. I knew Shearing a little and knew how he felt about this, just kind of figuring on the basis of the Miles association and whatnot that it was a pretty good shot at

Ahmad Jamal feeling positive about Bill Evans. Well the nice thing see about going out after those quotes, it so happens I got four quotes out of four people. But if it had taken eight or ten people to come up with the four good quotes nobody would have known that when the record came out. But those were the only four people, and as I say Miles' quote was in existence. Getting a quote from him might have been another whole thing but I didn't have to. I just would say Miles I'm going to use this, okay? And I called Jamal, who I did not know at all at that time, and told him what I was doing and asked if he'd like to participate and he said sure. Because he did feel strongly about it. But of all people to do that to, I mean this definite self-denying Bill Evans. When he found out what I was doing his only reaction was to say to me — because Bill had a very wicked sense of humor — he says, "why didn't you get a quote from my mother?" That record made a lot of noise, and of course very shortly after that he had the incredible brief good fortune of involving himself with Scott LaFaro, who was not only a magnificent bass player but he and Bill had a musical affinity that there's no point in trying to describe it because it's there on several records. And that of course, if you want to talk about serendipity the recording at the Village Vanguard of that Bill Evans Trio, Paul and Scott and Bill, was — well you've got to believe in something — good fairies or whatever — but first of all I had recorded, I'd done two studio recordings with that trio. But I knew what was always true was it took forever to get Bill to agree to go into the studio. Actually the second studio record had been done just a couple of months before that. It wasn't time to record again, but I said it was a great opportunity where I can set up, record him live, takes a lot of the pressure — I don't have to ask him to go into the studio, I don't have to push on him that way. So we set that up and actually the way it worked out we knew we wanted to do a Sunday because in those days the Sunday matinee was a firm part of the jazz week. So by going in there on one day you got two whole shows, the Sunday matinee and the Sunday evening. What we did was we were working on the last Sunday of a three week engagement. The engagements of that length also were the norm at that point. We are now in 1961 we're talking, right? So we go in there on what turns out to be the last day of the gig. But not only is it the last day of the gig, that's the last time that trio ever worked together because ten days later Scottie is killed in a car accident. So one of the favorite spooky things about that is during the first afternoon set, during I think the second number of the first afternoon set, there is a brief power outage and we lost about a minute and a half out of a tune. But nobody ever found out what caused it. It never recurred. We could have very easily said oh shit, the power went out, we weren't able to record that day. And boy would that have been a loss. But we did this thing, we did it at what turned out to be the last possible moment. That's such a legendary and famous record that a year ago in the spring of 2001 when we were approaching the 40th

anniversary of that recording, I got a call from a *New Yorker* writer, Adam Gopnick. I was interviewed, Paul was interviewed, Lorraine Gordon, who incidentally is the woman who I obliquely referred to under her first married name, the woman who was originally married to Alfred Lion at Blue Note ended up being married to the widower and now, for a number of years the owner of the Village Vanguard. So Lorraine was the best they could do in terms of dealing with the Vanguard thing. So I got to be quoted in the *New Yorker* as a result of having recorded Bill Evans. I mean that is really fame, isn't it? Isn't that really recognition?

MR: My favorite musician actually, ever, is Cannonball and Nat. Actually I think of them together an awful lot. And I wanted to play something if I could, from amongst the things that you had a hand in, and maybe you can just tell me about what you think about him as a person. Let's see if I can find it here.

OK: Well I'd be more than happy to talk to you about Cannonball and about what I think of him as a person. He was one of the very best people that I've ever known in my life. With that for a teaser we'll listen to the music and then I'll talk to you.

[audio interlude]

OK: Now you realize what just happened there? I mean I was going to point it out but you had the right part of the tune on. This is "Gemini," by another wonderful jazz musician/composer and human being, Jimmy Heath, who fortunately is one of the few old associates of mine who is still with us. And that recording, and you heard a taste of it right there, it's a live recording at the Village Vanguard, and this is the sextet at the time, that Yusef Lateef was added to the body of it, and Joe Zawinul is already in place as a piano player there. But every night that they played this song the same thing happened, it just happened there, there is this — in the midst of the solos, after the horn solos and before the piano solo, there's a return to a shout chorus and a secondary melody is played by the band, and invariably what happened there is that ensemble piece gets applause at the end in the same way that a solo does. And it just happened on that fragment of record that you played and that is always — I cannot recall that ever happening before or since as part, and as I say it became a routine part. Every audience reacted the same way. I mean I can't say that every audience did but I know it happened a hell of a lot and it certainly happens, as we hear now, the night that we were recording.

MR: Well that's one thing I loved about his bands is he had, even though it was a quintet or sextet, they had arrangements in there.

OK: Oh they had a very strong sense of arrangements, strong sense of composition in that band. The best way to describe my feelings about Julian Adderley is that I have learned over the years that no matter how close you can become to someone when you are working together, it is extremely difficult to maintain that relationship after the end of the

period of working together. Because the circumstances change. I mean you don't have that regularity because practically you're always either planning or doing or coming off of a record date when you're working together. And there's a great deal of planning together and hanging out together. And when that goes, what you have to recognize is you're not going to have in most cases, that same kind of closeness. And you have to realize nobody's mad at anybody necessarily. Sometimes yes, but very often not, it's just that your paths don't cross that often and you're working paths are now different. So I have over the years become very used to that fact that some people who I was very close to when we were working together, there was a falling off of that. Now I worked with Cannonball for a six year period from 1958 to 1964. The end of that relationship was when Riverside collapsed and had its financial disaster and was no more. Incidentally right up to the end of that period Cannonball, whose contract was expiring at almost exactly what turned out to be the time that the company expired, he was pushing on me. He said look I know how unsettled everything is. I was fighting very hard. My partner had died from a heart attack the previous December. Everything about the company was heavily mortgaged and we were really in hock and struggling to stay alive, had no idea whether we were going to make it or not. Cannonball said to me look, obviously if you can announce that you are retaining your major artist, and Cannon was our major selling artist, that's going to be helpful to you. So why don't we just — he says I don't know any more than you do how long you're going to last, but why don't we just announce that you have re-signed me, and what we will do is we will continue the present contract for one more year, under the same terms. And believe me he was worth a hell of a lot more. Just extend it as is for a year, give you that year of breathing room, let's see what develops. Actually what I finally had to do was to tell him, and we equivocated and went back and forth, him offering, me saying I don't know, and at one point I remember he was working someplace in Upstate New York and we were on the phone together and I said look Julian, I have made a final decision. Wonderful as you are you're not going to be enough — nothing is going to be enough to ensure the survival of this company and I don't want you trapped into an ongoing agreement with a dead company that has passed into somebody else's hands, so what I am telling you is this is a definite decision. If I call you tomorrow and tell you something else don't pay attention to that. This is it. Go away. So I literally had to kick my star act out of the house. But an indication of what kind of a guy he was is that he had made that offer. And then the important thing and in light of what I've been saying about when you're not working together, we next got together in 1973, when I first joined Fantasy. I was hired to come out to California to run the expanding Fantasy Records jazz program. And one of the things that they were negotiating, I had nothing to do with this I wasn't involved with it, they were negotiating to pick up

Cannonball, who was coming near the end of his Capitol contract and Capitol wasn't doing anything in jazz at that point. And so Cannonball and I ended up together at Fantasy for what turned out to be the last few years of his life. But in that intervening period between 1964 when Riverside died, and 1973 when we both were together at Fantasy, in that period we remained close personal friends. And we saw a lot of each other, we talked to each other a lot, we shared non-musical things, and that I have to say is among the handful of things that I feel best about, in my career. So I hope that's some kind of an answer to what I think about Cannonball Adderley. And this was among the things that he insisted on doing, and did some very valuable work in — I'd say he was my star pupil. I mean he became a producer, there was a whole series of "Cannonball Adderley Presents" which were pretty evenly divided between his trying to resurrect the careers of neglected older players, or he was trying to discover new players. Chuck Mangione's first record was made — I don't know whether Cannon should get credit for that or otherwise — but no Chuck was a damn good player. And he did a wonderful record with Cleanhead Vinson. And he did a wonderful record with Budd Johnson. You talk about underrated tenor players. There's a wonderful Budd Johnson record on Riverside called "Budd Johnson and the Four Brass Giants." The idea was let's do Budd Johnson with a trumpet section. Cannon put this thing together with his dates for the trumpet section was Sweets Edison, Clark Terry, Nat Adderley and oh God the Ellington trumpet player who also played wonderful violin.

MR: Oh Ray Nance.

OK: Ray Nance. Ray was the fourth trumpet player and doubled violin on a couple of numbers. So that was a throw-away idea of his.

MR: Well the one record too that was from right here in San Francisco I believe, where you had the idea to keep his crowd talk on the record.

OK: Well that was part of the first live date that we did with him and it became a signature thing. That was the first breakthrough record and the first hit record that I ever had, actually, The Cannonball Adderley Quintet in San Francisco was "Live at the Jazz Workshop," which was for many years a famous jazz club in this town. And that was actually, like all good hit albums, was propelled by one song really. It had Bobby Timmons' "This Here" which became an incredibly well put — it was funny, that was about a twelve minute long track and you know where you're not supposed to get it — but what we discovered was see in jazz at that point, as we're going from the 50s into the 60s, a lot of the radio strength of jazz was in those all night disc jockeys, the guys that were on from before midnight into the dawn and stuff, like Symphony Sid in New York, like Sid McCoy in Chicago, and in most cases, because these guys were operating on clear channel 50,000 watt stations which lots of other stations went off the air in the

middle of the night, you could hear them forever. I think if you were being played by Symphony Sid in New York and by Sid McCoy out of WCFL I guess in Chicago, you could be heard practically everywhere. And these guys loved long numbers because they could then take a break, have a sandwich, go to the bathroom, whatever. I mean they loved twelve minute tunes. So the juxtaposition worked very well indeed. And that was I guess if my first artistic break was Monk, my second and my first commercial break was the Cannonball record, which really put us and him on the map in a lot of ways. And it's interesting because that record, it established the label, it established the artist, I think it also did a hell of a lot, and I don't know whether this is good or bad, but just the whole concept of live recording of jazz, not just that there hadn't been such records before but this was a monster hit and a live record and it just, that whole idea of being able to catch and transfer the atmospherics of it, that whole excitement, the live ambience of the jazz performance in the jazz club and the audience reaction and such. It was a turning point there also. And you've got to remember, the other thing is when you're recording, in those days, it's not later when we get into the multi-track period and recording live means parking a truck outside which is really like a mobile control room and multi-track machines in the truck and they run the cable into the room, by contrast what we would basically do is set up in a corner someplace, it's like we were in the two track days at this time, with a portable Ampex machine and hope that — there are lines going to our machines from the bandstand, and hope that — what happened one night I remember in a live recording at the old Five Spot was a customer kicked one of our cables and the plug came out of the wall and that was the end of that take. But you hope that didn't happen too often. So to get good records out of that was a lot of fun and a lot of work too.

MR: Okay. I think we're going to change tapes here for a second, then we'll have a few more minutes.

[pause]

OK: I forgot to warn you but I think you learned on the job very quickly that when I get started the toughest thing is how do you interrupt and get to ask another question or change the subject.

—his whole attitude and his sincerity and his warmth. He was a hell of a human being. And you know the thing was that I had been intrigued by his carrying on and talking to the audience at a time when what was much more normal was the Miles Davis turn your back, then leave the bandstand during the other guy's solo kind of approach. And Cannon was this whole ongoing thing, and with talking to the audience, and not talking down but just talking. And it was something that we had it on tape and I just decided it was — sometimes some of the most successful things you do you look back and they represent, like weird gambles that you took. Because the whole idea, like here's like at least a

twelve minute track but we're a minute and twenty seconds into it before there's a note of music, and that's the beginning of the record. The beginning of the record is Cannonball introducing this song and talking about it, and then beginning to play it. And it's the kind of thing, well if it had been a bad idea and it had led to the record flopping we wouldn't necessarily have known it as a bad idea because it just wouldn't have happened and nobody would have been particularly aware of it. So the nice thing about taking chances like that is if you lose the penalty is just obscurity and nobody keeps track of that, you're kind of expected to be obscure most of the time with jazz records. But if it succeeds, what a wonderful idea, what a fabulous technique.

MR: Plus at that time, how long was a side of an LP?

OK: Well you wouldn't want to be much over twenty minutes.

MR: Okay. So your time was in a sense a little more valuable too. To give up a minute twenty for someone talking.

OK: Oh yeah. But nevertheless I just felt this was such a characteristic of the guy, and we did the same thing, because if you can remember back before the CD, there was side one and there was side two. And since one might be marked one, your second most important spot on an LP, and for audience attention but more particularly for disc jockey attention, was the first tune on the second side. See that no longer exists now when old LPs are translated into CDs, that's just something in the middle. But we actually were hedging our bets just a little bit on that one. We thought, judging from audience reaction that "This Here" was going to be the monster breakout song that it turned out to be. But we weren't a hundred percent sure, and it was another number that got tremendous reaction, this was the first recording as far as I know of Randy Weston's "High Fly" which of course has become quite a classic in its own right, and so we put that as the first number on the B side, as a back-up. And that's got a wonderful — it also starts with Cannon talking. And he talks about how Randy Weston, a lot of whose best numbers were in 6/8 and that Randy Weston has become to be known in jazz circles as the waltz king. And he says I don't mean Wayne King. But so we had a talk introduction on each side. We were hedging our bets but going for broke with the talk concept.

MR: It's interesting that both of those tunes are 6/8 feels. Who would expect?

OK: He got into 6/8 a lot. And what he said was of course one of the things, he said like the bad thing about having a hit is you've got to play it every God damn night probably every God damn set. But he said that one was always a lot of fun, "This Here" because audiences would feel impelled to rhythmically clap along with it, but for the most part they didn't have the faintest idea that it was in 6/8. So they were in there clapping on two and four, you know.

MR: You had a small anecdote, I don't know if you want to mention the person's name again, that you said something about Nat chasing some piano player down the street.

OK: Oh no that's a lovely story. Bobby Timmons was of course the Adderley's, this band's first piano player. And Cannon had been kind of a little unhappy about circumstances, he really wanted to have Bobby in the band but it meant in effect stealing him away from Art Blakey, you know the year before Bobby had wrote "Moanin'" which had been a great hit for Blakey, and after a while Bobby for one reason or another decided to go back to Blakey. And Cannon's idea of filling the vacant chair was this really wonderful young piano player in Detroit that he was aware of, musicians were very aware of, that hadn't been on the scene, Barry Harris. And one of the reasons that Cannonball hired Barry was because there was a degree of musical erudition and a melodic quality to Barry and Cannon was kind of concerned, he didn't want the band to become like known as nothing but a funk band, and nothing but the band that plays "This Here." So he brought Barry in partially to emphasize a more melodic side of the band, but very early in Barry's regime there is this incessant demand for "This Here" that it gets played every set because that's what the audience is looking for and that's what's getting all the airplay. And it's not Barry Harris' kind of music. Barry was pretty unhappy having to consistently play that tune. And basically Barry always has been a pretty good team player and he wasn't hollering too much about it, but he was uncomfortable and after a while it begins to get you down. And what he started to do was kind of to Burlesque the tune a little bit, to make fun of it somewhat, to play it more and more broadly. As he once said I think he was going to play it the way Jelly Roll Morton would have played it. I mean as long as we're doing this kind of thing, you know, so that it got to be noticeable that he was doing pretty much of a parody version of it. And Nat Adderley, who in addition to being the younger brother, really was the guy that took care of business and took care of paying people and was pretty much the straw boss of the band, and he felt that if band discipline was his problem, Cannonball was too easygoing anyhow. So quite a thing developed between him and Barry about his wanting Barry to stop playing the tune that way and Barry in effect feeling it was the only way he could preserve his sanity, it was the only way he could give himself some relief from having to play this damn thing all the time. And it just came to a head one night, actually it was during a return engagement at the Jazz Workshop, which probably made the whole thing worse and Barry just played the screwed up version of "This Here" once too often as far as Nat was concerned, and what happened was really there was a big shouting match going on and a guy going after a guy and Barry was out the front door and running down the street with Nat running after him. He finally gave up, didn't catch up with him, don't know what he would have done if he

did, and actually that relieved the tension a lot. But it's a story worth remembering. I don't think Barry will object to it, and I understand exactly what he was doing.

MR: Right. Well it's funny, it's almost the same thing with rock bands. They have a hit and people want to hear it, but those things are fortunate for the bands I think. Did you feel good about what happened with Cannonball's music and career in later years when he was with Capitol and so forth?

OK: Well it's funny, the answer always has to be yes and no. Because I'll always — if I look at somebody who went on and it happened to practically everybody. I mean for instance if you ask me that question about Wes Montgomery I would have no trouble saying definitely not did I think that what happened to Wes was terrible and very possibly shortened his life because I know that he was pretty uptight about being put into this pop bag and playing all these heavily arranged and pop-derived material but Cannon pretty much retained control over what he was doing. To the extent that when — I mean I mentioned that he and I were back together at Fantasy and that was at a point where yeah I was the VP running the jazz program at Fantasy but Cannon was in there on a contract that gave him pretty much control over what he did. And he started out, he and I both enjoyed the fact that I was taking care of my business, he was taking care of his. I wasn't involved in his record dates. Then we ran into some problems mainly with a couple of his albums being seriously over budget and such and the situation was getting a little strained between artist and label and I was asked to step in and see if I could heal the breach and so I ended up actually on I think the last two albums that Cannonball did at Fantasy before he died. There actually are three producers on each of those albums. They're produced by Cannon, Nat and me. And actually we did work together on it. But in a sense we had been working together back in the old days too. So I would say that what happened to his career, it's always been tragic the way it was cut short. The man had a stroke and never regained consciousness. And he was only in his 40s. But I didn't feel badly about that, I felt I wasn't happy with what happened to Monk's career at Columbia where for the most part, there were a few exceptions and there were a couple of interesting big band things, but for the most part it was the working group over and over again, and Monk and I had been very happy with the variations that we were able to do and the interesting guests and associations that we were able to bring in, I just think that what happened there was he took the path of least resistance, nobody really gave him — because there were some large things where like "Big Band at Lincoln Center," a live performance big band stuff. The final Monk record for Columbia which was the Oliver Nelson arrangements I thought just lost the whole spirit of Monk so badly that it was not a good record. But I guess there was a case where the artist left his association with me primarily because the people who were running his career then feeling it was time to take

him up a notch to a major label, and he was pulled away from us. And I didn't think anything sensible or helpful or intelligent was done to his career subsequently. Bill Evans also went on to a — although there what happened was he kind of knew that he was kind of good in the sense that even though when Bill first went to Verve, and that was a matter of Bill left Riverside with a year to go on his contract which was because we were in existence, we were starting to have real money problems and frankly Bill had turned into one of the most expensive junkies I ever had to be involved with, represented more of a burden than we really could comfortably handle. I mean I have said this and I've written about this before, it's not anything new, but being his record company, his friend, and his producer all at the same time was a hell of a strain on me. I did not appreciate the way that whole thing came down at the end. And what happened was with a year to go and Creed Taylor was extremely anxious to have Bill as his artist, and bring him over to Verve, so that a buyout kind of thing was arranged. I retained the right to do two more albums with Bill and of the sizable advance that he got from Verve, half of it was in the form of a check to Riverside Records which represented only a partial repayment of what we had over-advanced him. It's interesting and shows the passage of time. In a sense this is related to what had happened eight years earlier with Riverside buying Monk out of his Prestige contract but the amounts were hugely different. But Bill, what happened there as far as the artistic content, after a very little while something, and I never have felt it was any of my business even knowing, but something was not right in the working relationship between Bill and his producer there, and Bill's manager, a woman who was very, very important in his life, Helen Keane, took over as Bill's producer and actually did serve as a producer of the rest of his output. That included a funny period, he also was at Fantasy in the early 70s, and actually I think Helen and I intended to co-produce a live date together. Bill was recorded — well we initially intended to record it at Shelly's Manne-Hole in Los Angeles but Shelly's had just moved from its original funky location into the basement of a bank building and there was a big — the air conditioning equipment broke down and the whole floor of the club was covered in about a foot of oil out of the equipment. So we canceled that one out and ended up recording him at the Vanguard and Helen got sick and didn't make it so I ended up doing that one by myself. So we never did get to co-produce it, which probably was a good idea. But Bill actually was pretty — see Bill knew what he wanted and was pretty insistent on it as Cannon was. But Bill was doing trio albums the rest of his life with occasional guests on it. But he was fundamentally, he wanted to be a trio piano player and he fundamentally was. So nobody messed with him artistically too much that way.

MR: Speaking of him I wanted to get your reaction on this if I could. Let's see if I found the kind of, this is like a blindfold test.

OK: Since I don't know what you put on. Okay.

[audio interlude]

MR: I always wondered what was going on in the booth especially.

OK: This is the —

MR: "Peace Pieces."

OK: Well "Peace Piece" is literally what it always was identified as being. "Peace Piece" was an improvisation, it is true that what he was setting out to do was to create an introduction to a recording of "Some Other Time," the Leonard Bernstein, Comden and Green song. He started messing around and found that gee, this was something very interesting in and of itself so that literally that was created at the record date. I mean nobody went in there with the intention — now actually the title was in existence but not to be used on that tune. There is a solo piece called "Epilogue" which is on the end of each side of that album originally. That was originally going to be called "Peace Piece." So the title was there and then this thing was created, and this goes much better with that title, but it literally was a spontaneously generated thing. And the interesting part of that is, a couple of interesting stories. One is although unfortunately the tape for some reason did not survive as sometimes happens, nobody thought in terms of alternates and whatnot, "Peace Piece" as issued is approximately fifty percent from one take and fifty percent from another. If you like the beginning of — I think he just did it twice. He liked the beginning of one, liked the end of the other, obviously no problem splicing together. But it sure would have been nice at some stage of the game to be able to issue the rejected halves, but they did not survive for whatever reason. And that frequently happens. Oh yeah, session takes that the good things have been taken out of, where are they? It doesn't matter. So that is one point. Also he maintained for years that he couldn't play it again because it had never been notated and it just existed as free improvisation. Towards the end though I do believe he had gotten himself to where he played it, he re-created it and played it a few times. But essentially it was what it was, a total improvisation starting from an initial concept which was that he was trying to do something that would fit as an intro to "Some Other Time."

MR: Right. Did you have a feeling when it was over that this is going on the album, right away?

OK: Well actually what happens is when anything gets done at a record session the only unusual thought I'm going to have is gee this is lousy, this is not going to go on the album. We're in the studio to make the album, why not start with that. And even something that's added like that, because after all jazz is a music of improvisation is it not? So it's not a matter of gee, isn't that wonderful. It's probably gee isn't it wonderful we didn't waste our damn time, studio time is expensive.

MR: What was the typical budget? I don't know if you can say typical?

OK: You can't do that for several reasons. One reason you can't do that is that I'm talking now basically late 50s, early 60s, the value of the dollar is so outrageously different that you can't make comparisons. Even if you allow for this, that or the other, you lose all sense of — I mean there were no journeymen ball players making over a million dollars a year in those days, just to take an example of the world of entertainment and how things have changed. Also another thing I like to point out was that now there's a lot, because like I say everything was a lot cheaper but it didn't really mean that much because the standard of living was different, everything cost less, but what it really boils down to is you got paid less for things. It was fourteen cents for a loaf of bread or whatever, but the fact of the matter is when you get down to the irreducible minimum and it's still dollars that are being paid, the difference is important, so that it is relevant to point out that union scale for a musician recording, a sideman doing three hours of work in which fifteen minutes of music for an album could be created, scale was $41.25. Now that was not outrageously bad but it just — what is scale today?

MR: I don't know anymore. It's a lot more than that.

OK: Well the scale today is several hundred dollars. So that whatever, and I must confess I should know better but I've gotten to the point where the reason I'm not — I mean I still do a certain amount of recording but I've gotten into the habit where you pay sidemen a lump sum that is never going to be as small as what scale is so I mean I don't even deal in terms of thinking about things that way. Nevertheless the whole point is that we did records very economically. Let's put it that way. The fact is that you could do a trio record and your musicians costs might total $500. You know you might roughly speaking be paying $125 to each sideman and $250 to the leader and that's probably what got paid on the first Bill Evans album. And nothing — nobody was exploiting anybody. It also meant that even though the record only sold 800 copies in the first year, so we didn't come out ahead on it, but it was not unthinkable to say let's continue working with this guy. Because he deserves to be recorded. So you can't — and I do absolutely refuse to try and translate — it would take, maybe if I got on somebody's program sometime in the presence of let's say a jazz fan who was also a significant economist, we could have a discussion about that, and I'd love to do that sometime. Unfortunately I've never ever come across such a person. I would love to talk with such a person and it certainly should be, by all means, should be a public conversation — a lot of people — I would love to know more myself about what that relationship is. What I do know is this, I know it was possible to make jazz records without having any significant or even noticeable amount of capitalization. That's the important fact. That a bunch of young guys with a lot of balls and ambition and love of the music and very little capital were able to create record

companies. That could not happen today even though people are constantly still trying to do it. And there were a number of other factors you see. We were kind of famous for not having rehearsals. Even though there was written material but what you have to point out then is we were working and made sure we were working with people who were tremendously familiar with playing with each other. If I had a rhythm section that technically didn't have a rehearsal they nevertheless had been playing together probably for about ten years, that'll do as far as being able to get things out of each other and being able to work together. And that would be not that easy to do today, though there is still a tendency, I mean I fight hard to get — to work with people who know each other who can shortcut the time and don't have to be introduced to each other at the date, but you just won't get back to — that was the climate. I mean the scene in New York was a very real part of what we did, a lot of interaction between a lot of talented musicians. And again at Riverside there was a tremendous amount of people associated with the label playing on other people's dates, not because we asked them to because they told us — I'm going to be — I mean the second record I did with Jimmy Heath, who everybody really loved, was because Jimmy was such a great writer we just pulled it together and got Jimmy, we did like a ten-piece date, seven horns kind of thing. And it was easy, we knew who the bass player and the drummer were going to be, they were going to be Percy and Tootie [Heath], but there were two trumpets on that album called "Really Big," which is a wonderful, medium band, Jimmy Heath album from about 1961. Well the trumpet players on that are Nat Adderley and Clark Terry because they told me they were going to be. The alto is Cannonball because he said so. And Cannonball only plays one solo on the thing. We were not trying to milk the famous artist and have this really, like it was featuring him or something. But there he was because he damn well said he was going to be there. And I think for some reason we changed piano players between sessions so we had I think Flanagan on one and Cedar Walton on the other, that kind of thing. Now some of that is like names didn't have the same meaning that they do today. I mean everybody says wow, a Thelonious Monk record with John Coltrane and Coleman Hawkins on it. Wow. Well it's a wonderful record but it was not a record that was made with two famous tenor players. It was a record made with one tenor player who was considered to be over the hill, and one who hadn't happened yet. But those are important points to remember when you're milking the nostalgia of an old cat like me to remember that a lot of times you have to look below the surface. It's the same as don't take Miles Davis' word for anything. Investigate what the truth of it is. It's the same kind of situation. Don't just look at the personnel listing and say wow, those guys must have spent a lot of money to put this band together.

MR: Well I know that you have to go, and so I—

OK: Well this has been a great pleasure. I could easily continue endlessly but I don't know if you necessarily want me to. But I have enjoyed it. I hope all kinds of good things are made of things. And I do want to end up with a copy of what I have said.

MR: Absolutely. You know jazz has been elevated, or whatever, I'm not sure of the right word, to a high state of art these days. Do you think it's been positive for jazz?

OK: That's a hard question to answer. I do feel that when I have attended the last few jazz educators conventions and I am pleased to see — I used to frown on jazz education because those God damn stage band so-called which were nothing but tired old big band charts and there were important things like the fact that if it wasn't for North Texas State how would Woody Herman ever get new players for his band, all those cliches of the past. But the fact is I think that to some degree jazz education has done a wonderful job, it has progressed, there are people learning things on stages of the game where people never were learning before. As long as you recognize there is only one of a series of tools and it is by no means like is that the only way to go, so that I would say on the whole, hey, if you asked me did I think that multi-track recordings was a positive or a negative experience I'd say pretty much the same thing. If you keep it under control it's just fine. If you use it, if you don't let it use you, if you use the fact of jazz education, the proliferation of it in so many places, if you use that to the purposes of making good jazz it's fine. But don't let it run away with you. I guess that's — I feel that way about technical progress, I mean I love digital recording, I have always been of several minds about multi-track for just that reason, I don't want the bass player to be able to punch in the right notes, I want it to be important what notes he was playing when they were listening to him while they were playing. So that makes me an anachronism in some ways I know. But so be it.

MR: All right. Good answer. Thank you for your time.

OK: Thank you for having me.